Pietro Carrera — Il gioco de gli scacchi (1617)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 17 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Don Pietro Carrera of Militello, Sicilian priest and chess writer, who in 1617 saw the first book ever printed in his town come from its press, and set down in it both his argument for the game's Trojan origin and a new game of his own invention — the two parts William Lewis left out in 1822.

The author's own terms

Champion — his name for his greater new piece, the union of rook and knight, ranked third in his ordering after King and Queen; he might have called it “Rook-knight” but chose Champion. *Centaur* — his name for the lesser new piece, the union of bishop and knight; he might have called it “Bishop-knight.” *Riga* — in the origin chapter, his term for the ancient line-games, the Riga of Twelve, the Riga of Three, and *grammismus*, which he distinguishes from chess proper, as the contrast class of his Palamedes argument.

The story

Pietro Carrera was born on 12 July 1573 at Militello in Val di Catania and died on 18 September 1647 at Messina, on the modern reference record. Lewis's 1822 preface, which the folder follows for the year, gave 1571 instead; that

year is not printed here as settled.

On the modern reference record, he was schooled at the Seminario Diocesano of Siracusa and met Paolo Boi, “the Siracusan,” at Palermo in 1597; after his vows he served as chaplain at S. Maria della Stella and then at the court of Francesco Branciforte, Prince of Pietraperzia and Marchese of Militello, at whose request the chess book was printed, and after Branciforte's death in 1622 he moved to Messina.

The work and what survives

Il gioco de gli scacchi di D. Pietro Carrera, diviso in otto libri (Militello: Giovanni de' Rossi, 1617) covers the rules, odds, endgames, and the game's origins in eight books. It was the first book ever printed in Militello, corroborated by two independent sources.

This project holds a fresh English rendering, from the 1617 Italian and never borrowing a line from Lewis, of two units: Book I, Chapter I, “Of the Inventor of the Game of Chess,” and Book VIII, Chapter II, “Of the New Game.” In the first, Carrera argues from Homer, Herodotus, Euripides, Sophocles, Plato, Ovid, Seneca, Martial, and others that Palamedes invented chess at the siege of Troy. In the second, he sets his new game on a board of eighty squares, eight by ten. Lewis's preface described that board as one of “ninety-six squares”; that figure is Lewis's error, not Carrera's board. One passage of the 1617 page is too broken in the scan to read with certainty; the rendering gives only the recoverable sense, and the board diagram's lettering, likewise lost, is described in words from Carrera's directions.

Its English fortunes

Lewis's 1822 English Carrera deliberately omitted the origin chapter and the new-game chapter; no English rendering of either chapter was found after research.

Lewis's *A Treatise on the Game of Chess* (London, 1822) remains the only English Carrera traced, and, in his preface as quoted in the folder, he made an exception of Carrera's account of chess players, which he did translate; that account is not part of the gap here. English summaries of the origin argument

exist, and variant literature paraphrases the new game's rules extensively; neither is a translation. The bound: web searches were run on 17 October 2026, with no WorldCat or union-catalogue sweep and no systematic search of chess-history anthologies or variant literature for quoted passage-renderings, which would narrow the claim at passage level only.

What completing it would take

For the slice as scoped, nothing further in scope: the two omitted units are rendered, with both scan disclosures above. What remains is verification. The birth year must be settled at primary strength before the life is printed with a single unqualified year. The chapters must be collated against the 1617 page images at the scan-broken passage, and a passage-level check of the variant and chess-history literature made, before any stronger wording is used. The rendering has had no independent check by a reader of seventeenth-century Italian at this desk; the folder marks it as not yet having the final checks required before any public use. The rest of Carrera is not this project's work: Lewis covers the practical body and the players' account.

Sources

- Project folder: `~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/carrera-scacchi-omitted-chapters/carrera-scacchi-omitted-chapters.txt`
- PIN: `~/workspace/packages/boneyard-extension/research/PIN-carrera.md`
- Modern reference record: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Pietro_Carrera
- Lewis preface transcription: https://www.chess.com/blog/batgirl/carreras-history-of-chess-players
- Dominic Winter catalogue: https://www.dominicwinter.co.uk/cms/lotdetailspdf/398698/
- *Chess History and Reminiscences* summary: https://www.bookrags.com/ebooks/4902/62.html